was added to my daily routine as a consequence. Maa dropped me and Dada there at ten every morning and picked me up at twelve. Dada would come home later with Papaji, owing to the difference in the timings of our classes. Some days I would insist on staying at school longer. I think I liked being there. But my teacher felt otherwise.

'Come on, Gunjan . . . Come inside,' Maa called as I stopped in our garden one afternoon, listening to a strange voice that seemed to be coming from the other side of our bungalow's boundary. She had just picked me up from school and reached home.

'You want to go back to school?' she asked as she walked towards me, my little school bag still slung on her shoulder. But all my attention was focused on the sound.

'Look, I'll let you and Dada play once he's back from school. But let us first change out of this frock and eat some food, okay?' she said while caressing my face. I didn't move an inch.

'Maa . . .' I said, raising my hand to point in the direction of the sound. Gestures were an alternative to my speech, which was still developing.

'Okay, we'll play wherever you want. Now let's go inside,' she misinterpreted, as she gently picked me up and took me inside. By then the sound had stopped. As I ate my mashed potatoes and daal-rice, I kept thinking about that sound. I had heard it before.

'Wow! You ate it all, little lady. How much did you play today?' Maa commented as she fed me one last spoonful. Normally, I would make it a tough job for her. But I finished my meal quietly, since I wanted to rush outside and solve the mystery of the new sound as soon as possible. Maa sat me down on the sofa and went to the kitchen. Unattended, I leapt at the opportunity and rushed back outside, running in short baby steps straight to the backyard. Monsoon clouds had gathered in the sky and it was about to rain. There was a dump of debris at a point adjacent to the boundary wall in the backyard, which I could climb. It felt like a small hillock back then, but nevertheless, I made it to the top. For a moment I remained there, listening for that sound again, and a faint one soon reached my ears. In an attempt to catch a glimpse of what it was, I stood on my toes and leaned forward. The